

DIRECTOR'S CHAIR
For his next film, Elan has three completed scripts to choose from

FILMS

A Star Is Born

Star, *a coming-of-age Tamil drama film, shows that its director* **Elan** *has matured since his directorial debut*

Elan burst onto the Tamil cinema scene out of nowhere. Beginning young, he admits he was lucky to make his directorial debut at 23—with the fresh, thoughtful, enlightened romantic comedy *Pyaar Prema Kaadhal* in 2018. And then it took six years for his sophomore film *Star* with Kavin in the lead. The film deals with Kalai (Kavin), an aspiring actor with dreams of becoming Tamil cinema's next star. Kalai is the son of a photographer played by Lal, a father who is more enthusiastic and bullish about his son's chances. Elan's father too is a still photographer turned actor—Stills Pandian—but the autobiographical aspect ends there. Elan is positive about the long gap between his first two films. "I started very young; I made my first film at 23. I felt like I didn't have enough life experience to tell some stories, so this time helped." For example, there are parts of *Star*, according to Elan, that evolved almost subconsciously in his head. The scene on the terrace when Kalai requests his father to watch him perform was different. "I had a more theatrical performance in mind for that scene," he says. "Something changed within me, so that four-five years after writing that scene, on location I went for a more subtle delivery from Kavin."

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The most compelling part of *Star* is when Kalai goes through a period of self-loathing after an accident that gives him a scar on his face. A mark that reminds him that he has no future as an actor every time he looks in the mirror. It leads to a complete breakdown of his mental health; he drives away even those who love him. It's a bold call for a mainstream film. "It was challenging. I took time to decide what exactly I wanted to say through this period in his life. And the other issue was to avoid making the film too depressing." It's one of the reasons he created the character of Surabi (Aaditi Pohankar). This stretch in the film divided audiences, the film though warmly received has drawn criticism for the complete lack of optimism in these portions. But Elan wanted to make a coming-of-age film, and these are staples of the genre. He wanted to show Kalai, warts and all. Real, with flaws and fighting his inner demons. "I was clear that this is not going to be a sports drama or a rag-to-riches kind of story. A lot of people expected what's next, what's next like a sports drama."

The trailer, much loved and setting high expectations for the film, might have played a part in this. "I felt that maybe the trailer should have conveyed that this will be a slow-moving drama. Maybe there should have been a foreshadowing that the second half will go into this zone." Where does he go next? "I have a fantasy script, an alternate history satire, a superhero film. But I don't know which one I'll make." But he is sure he will return sooner this time. ■

–Aditya Shrikrishna